Gambling and its Characteristics

Gambling is the wagering of money or something of material value on an event with an uncertain outcome with the primary intent of winning additional money /or material goods.

Difference between gambling and betting:

Betting: is an act of risking a sum of money on the outcome of a future event (other people's effort).

Gambling: is to play games of chance for money.

Types of Gambling:

- ***Casino games***- While almost any game can be played for money, and any game typically played for money can also be played just for fun, some games are generally offered in a casino setting.
  - Table games- Cards and Dice.
  - Electronic gaming- Pachinko, Slot machine, Video poker, Video bingo
  - Other gambling- Bingo, Keno
- ***Non-casino gambling games***- Gambling games that take place outside of casinos include Bingo (as played in the US and UK), dead pool, lotteries, pull-tab games and scratch cards, and Mahjong.
  - Other non-casino gambling games include: Card games
- ***Pokémon game (film heroes' fictional characters****), there are cards for these characters played by children and adults which can be bought, sold and pool and its values "price" vary*
- **Sports betting**- Betting on team sports has become an important service industry in many countries. For example, millions of people play the football pools every week in the United Kingdom. In addition to organized sports betting, both legal and illegal.
- ***Shop Contests based on drawing (lottery),*** *no one can enter without buying the competition coupon or buying merchandise to raise the price from the usual to contribute by part of the price of the prize.*
- Competitions that are required to pay for calling certain number, or send a certain message, or any financial cost, like Dream contest, and who wants to be a millionaire …etc.

Legal Ruling of Gambling:

Gambling in Islam is haram or prohibited because Allah has forbidden it, and He rules as He wills. Allah says (interpretation of the meaning):

"O you who believe! Intoxicants (all kinds of alcoholic drinks), gambling, al-Ansaab [sacrifices for idols, etc.] and al-Azlaam [arrows for seeking luck or decision] are an abomination of Shaytaan's handiwork. So, avoid (strictly all) that (abomination) in order that you may be successful.

What if gambling involves no money?

Allah has said:" Satan only wants to cause between you animosity and hatred through intoxicants and gambling and to avert you from the remembrance of Allah and from prayer"

So the main reasons for prohibitions are the reasons mentioned in the above verse, and <u>not only the monetary aspect</u>. Therefore, It is not allowed if it causes the aforementioned sins, even if there is no monetary wager.

The wisdom behind this prohibition, any wise person will see that there are many reasons for it, including the following:

- Gambling makes a person rely on luck and wishful thinking for his earnings, instead of hard work, the sweat of his brow and paying respect to the ways prescribed by Allah.
- Gambling destroys families and causes the loss of wealth through haram means. It makes rich families poor and humiliates proud souls.
- Gambling causes stress, illness and nervous breakdowns. It breeds hatred and, in most cases, leads to crime, suicide, insanity and chronic illness.
- Gambling pushes the gambler to bad behavior such as drinking alcohol and taking drugs. Gambling destroys everything, even when the aim is money. It includes wine, smoking, bad company, darkness, confusion, cheating, and hatred, watching for opportunities to take advantage of others, deception and all other kinds of evil.

Competitions Excluded from Gambling (*Maisir*)

1. **Third-Party Sponsored Competitions:**

   Any competition where the prize is provided by a non-participant (such as a sponsor or donor). Because the competitors do not contribute to the prize pool, there is no risk of financial loss, which removes the element of prohibited gambling.

2. **Permissible Contests (Horse Racing, Camel Racing, and Archery):**

   Betting or prize allocation in horse races, camel races, and shooting competitions is permissible based on the Hadith of the Prophet (PBUH):

   > *"There should be no (money) prizes for competitions except in camel-racing, horse-racing and archery."*

   Muslim jurists unanimously agree on the permissibility of giving and receiving prizes in horse racing, camel racing, and javelin throwing/shooting contests. As Imam Ibn al-Qayyim said:

   > *"Allah and His Prophet (PBUH) permitted competition in arrow-shooting and in horse and camel racing in order to encourage Muslims to learn horse-riding and get prepared for Jihad."*

3. **Promotional Gift Vouchers and Store Rewards:**

   Gift vouchers offered by commercial shops to customers who make purchases over a specified amount. Since the customer pays only for their goods without an extra charge for entry, it contains no element of unlawful risk or gambling.

Conditions for Permissible Competitions

1. **Legitimate Purpose and Means:** The overall objectives and methods of the competition must be lawful, ethical, and serve a good purpose.
2. **Lawful Prize Source:** The prize money must not be funded by the contestants (or a subset of them), as this constitutes gambling. *(Exception: Horse racing, camel racing, and archery/marksmanship, where contestant-funded prizes are classical exceptions).*

3. **No Neglect of Obligations:** The competition must not lead to the omission of religious or worldly duties, nor involve any forbidden (*haram*) acts.
4. **Zero-Loss Participation:** Each contestant must experience a outcome where they either win a prize or leave without a loss—they must not lose original funds or incur financial penalty simply for participating.